

Eastern Sparks

First 2 Chapters

EASTERN SPARKS (BOOK 2)

Chapter 1: The City That Asks Everything

Sofia Vale · Tokyo, Japan — Ginza

The Narita Express didn't ease you into Tokyo. It withheld it, first — grey suburbs scrolling past in the rain, power lines making precise geometry against a sky the color of wet concrete, the occasional flash of rice field between industrial blocks. An ordinary world outside, ordinary in the way that precedes something.

Sofia had learned, eighteen months ago on a different train pulling into Santa Maria Novella, to stay in her seat one beat past the platform. She still did it. Not hesitation — consideration. The professional instinct to read a room before entering it, applied now to cities.

She read the window. Suburban Tokyo becoming urban Tokyo: the density compressing, buildings pressing closer, the power lines multiplying into a dark lacework overhead. A factory, a convenience store, a cluster of vending machines glowing neon in the grey afternoon, a man in a suit standing perfectly still on a platform as the train slid past. She watched his stillness. It wasn't the stillness of waiting. It was the stillness of someone who had already arrived somewhere in his mind.

Interesting, she thought, and stood.

Shinjuku station registered in the body before the mind caught up. The scale of it — corridors branching into corridors, signage in kanji she couldn't read yet, the deep harmonic hum of a hundred thousand people in controlled motion. She'd done 200-cover services in two countries by now. She understood high-volume human systems. She understood how a room with too many people in it could tip from organized to chaotic in a single bad moment, and how you could feel that tipping point coming if you learned to read the floor.

She read this floor.

Here: the tide patterns of rush hour around the barriers, people moving in streams that never quite collided because everyone had agreed, without discussion, on invisible lanes. There: a tourist couple halted mid-flow with a map, and the city parting around them the way a river parts around a rock — with total indifference, and no malice, and no waste. She adjusted her backpack straps and moved with the stream, reading exits by the angle of foot traffic rather than the signs. Found the right one in forty seconds.

Different place. Same floor.

She hadn't expected to feel competent immediately. But competence, it turned out, was partly just recognizing the patterns underneath the unfamiliar surface. A room full of people was a room full of people. You read the body language. You followed the energy. You stayed aware.

She went underground for the subway to Ginza, and the city swallowed her whole.

The apartment was a compact studio near Marunouchi — smaller than any room she'd lived in yet, which was saying something. A single bed, a fold-down desk, a window that looked onto the concrete flank of the building next door and, in a strip of sky perhaps thirty centimeters wide, a fragment of a maple tree. Its leaves were summer-green, absolutely still in the no-wind between buildings. She stood looking at it for longer than made sense. Something in its absolute stillness felt like a statement.

She unpacked with the efficiency of someone who'd done this five times now. Uniform out first: black trousers, white shirt, the apron she'd bought in Barcelona because the linen was better. She pressed the shirt with the travel iron even though she was tired and it could have waited. The shirt is armor. The name tag is a declaration. Avó had never said those words — they were Sofia's own formulation, arrived at somewhere between Florence and Barcelona — but they contained something her grandmother had taught her without words, in a cramped kitchen with two gas burners and the wooden spoon pressing into her palm. You show up exactly right, or you don't show up.

She showered. She slept for three hours, the sleep of someone whose body had decided the time zone argument was over. She woke to full darkness and the quiet hum of the city, different from any city she'd lived in — lower, more constant, like something running deeply beneath the surface. She lay still for a moment and let herself admit that she was frightened.

Not of the restaurant. Not of the work. She was good at the work now, and she knew she was good, which was different from being arrogant — it was just accurate. She was frightened in the way you're frightened when you've walked through a familiar kind of door and find the room on the other side arranged entirely differently than you expected. She knew how to read a room. She did not yet know how to read this country.

She got up. Got dressed. Made tea in the small kettle, standing at the window while the maple's leaves held their extraordinary stillness in the strip of sky. Somewhere in the building next door, someone played a single piano note and stopped.

Sweat and fire, menina.

Avó's kitchen, the wooden spoon. She pressed her palms together, felt them steady.

More of this, she told the maple. *Whatever comes next, more of this.*

The restaurant occupied the fourth floor of a building on Ginza's main avenue — understated entrance, unmarked from the street, accessible by a single elevator that opened onto a reception foyer lined in pale wood and washi paper. Twelve tables. Seven courses. Kappo-style: the kitchen visible behind a hinoki-wood counter where two chefs worked in silence so complete it seemed deliberate, as if sound itself had been plated and served in correct portion.

The restaurant manager, who introduced himself only as Yamamoto, was a slight man in his early fifties with the manner of someone who had decided, long ago, that nothing happening in the next hour could reasonably be considered an emergency. He showed her the floor in silence — moving between tables with a measured care that she recognized as its own kind of language. He didn't explain what he was showing her. He just showed it.

The head server was Matsuda-san: late forties, precise dark hair, eyes that registered everything without appearing to settle anywhere in particular. She had been at this restaurant for seventeen years. Sofia learned this later, from a junior server who said it the way you'd state an altitude or a weight — a fact that had its own dignity.

"Watch first," Matsuda-san said. Her English was spare and accurate. "Then do."

Her first shift was pure observation. She stood at her station and watched Matsuda-san move through service like something continuous and uninterrupted — not performance, not efficiency in the Western sense of visible hustle, but a kind of presence that was so thorough it looked like absence. She was there before you noticed she was there. She was gone before you noticed she'd gone. Plates arrived as if they'd always been there. Glasses refilled at the precise moment of need, before the guest considered wanting.

Sofia watched and understood, with a specific inward discomfort, that she did not yet know how to do this.

She knew how to do the Florence version: warm, attentive, quick to speak, quick to read the room and respond. She knew the Barcelona version: kinetic, read-the-chaos, find the rhythm in the noise. She'd developed, over eighteen months, an instinct for the moment a table needed her attention, and a voice that could calibrate from playful to reverent depending on the tone of the room.

This room had no tone she could match. It had something else — a frequency she hadn't learned to hear yet.

On her third shift, Yamamoto assigned her to a two-top: a Japanese businessman and his American colleague. A sake presentation — one selection from the evening's list, offered to accompany the second course.

She approached the table with the sake list and the small porcelain flask already chilled to the right temperature, and she began to describe it the way she'd described wines in Florence and Barcelona: the origin, the rice variety, the character of the water, the way it would move against what was coming from the kitchen. She was thorough. She was accurate. She had done her research. Two sentences became four.

The Japanese businessman looked at her with an expression that was perfectly polite and completely unreadable. The American colleague leaned slightly forward, engaged — she was giving him exactly what a Western service guest would want, which was the problem. She was giving the same thing to both of them, and the table was not both of them. The table was a Japanese professional whose relationship with this restaurant was one of trust established over many visits, sitting with a guest he was trying to make comfortable. What the Japanese host needed from her was not information. He needed the room to remain his.

She placed the flask and stepped back.

Matsuda-san appeared at her elbow from nowhere, the way she did, and said quietly: "Too many words."

No reproach. Just data.

On the fourth shift, Sofia came back to a different two-top — Japanese business guests again, no foreign visitor — and she adjusted. She placed the sake flask. Said one sentence. Withdrew.

The silence sat on the table like a live thing and she felt every centimeter of it, felt the instinct to fill it clawing at her professional composure. *She* was silent. But her silence was not calm. It was held breath. It was the silence of someone waiting to see if they'd made a mistake. The guest at the near seat glanced up, registered something in her posture, and looked back down at his plate.

She had the right idea. She had the wrong quality of stillness.

After service, she didn't ask Matsuda-san what had gone wrong. She'd learned, already, that questions here were answered in the next thing you saw, not the answer you were given. She watched Matsuda-san's closing routine — a slow circuit of the emptied restaurant, adjusting one chair's angle by perhaps three degrees, lifting a used candle from a holder and replacing it with the unhurried care of someone for whom this was not a chore but a completion.

She thought about her avó's nod. Small as a comma, large as a sentence.

On her sixth shift, she had a four-top near the window — two couples, international, clearly at ease with fine dining but not with the specific register of this restaurant. They were slightly loud, generous, the kind of table she'd learned to love in Florence because they responded to warmth with warmth. They wanted to be friends with their server. She felt the pull of it.

She placed the sake flask. Said the one sentence. Withdrew.

The silence gathered. She stood at her station and let it exist without filling it. This time the silence in her body was different — not held breath, not performance. It was just attention. She was present in the room without leaning toward the table. Aware without being trained on it. The way you read a floor without staring at any one point.

The guest nearest her turned after perhaps thirty seconds and asked, in English, what the sake was made from.

She stepped forward. She answered in three sentences: origin (Niigata, Uonuma water), character (dry and clean, what the Japanese call *karakuchi*), and pairing (the dashi approaching from the kitchen would clarify both). She stopped. She did not expand.

The man nodded. Then he said: "Karakuchi. I like that."

She refilled his cup, the small clean twist at the finish, stepped back.

Matsuda-san was at the far end of the room. She did not look up. But at the close of service, walking the circuit, she passed Sofia's station and paused for half a second. She placed two fingers lightly on the edge of the counter — a gesture so small it might have meant nothing.

It meant something.

Sofia felt it settle into her the way technique does when it graduates from memorized to owned. Not a sequence anymore. A frequency. She had been trying to learn silence as a discipline. It turned

out silence was a quality of attention, not an absence of speech. You could fill a room with your presence or empty yourself into it. What Tokyo wanted was the second thing: the server as a held breath, an interval, the negative space that let the guest hear themselves think.

Ma, she would learn the word for it later, from the junior server — Keiko, twenty-four, who had grown up in Kyoto and whose grandmother had been a geiko. *Ma*. Pause, space, the interval between notes that gives music its shape. The thing that is there when nothing is there.

She had just, for the first time, produced it.

The reservation book was on the counter in the foyer, leather-bound, the next evening's covers already entered in careful hand. She checked it as part of her post-service sweep — guest counts, VIP notes, any special preparations. Standard practice, the same in every restaurant she'd worked.

She scanned the entries. A two-top at 19:00, a six-top corporate booking at 19:30. Table nine: a VIP notation from the Four Seasons concierge — solo diner, regular of the concierge desk, European. The name written in the margin was neat and spare: *Voss, L.*

She made the notation in her working memory the way she noted any VIP — table nine, solo, European, Four Seasons — and moved on to the next entry. Five minutes later she was checking linen counts and the name was gone from her mind.

She left through the back entrance at midnight, the kitchen already dark, the alley behind the building smelling of cold concrete and somewhere far away, yakitori smoke from Yurakucho. The rain that had been threatening all evening had stopped. The street was wet and the reflections in the puddles — neon, a window, the moving light of a passing bicycle — were cleaner than the originals.

She stopped at a convenience store on the way back. Not for any reason in particular — for the human habit of light at this hour, the reliable geometry of a place where everything was in its exact position. She bought an onigiri and stood at the counter eating it, and the man behind the register said something in Japanese that she thought was probably a comment about the weather.

"*Hai*," she said, which was almost certainly not the correct response to whatever he'd said.

He smiled anyway. She bowed slightly, the small reflex she was already learning from the city around her.

Outside, the street was empty. The maple she could see from her apartment window would be still in the dark now — same leaves, same motionless quality, but invisible, folded into the night. She stood on the empty pavement with her hands in her jacket pockets and felt the city around her: enormous and indifferent and extraordinarily precise, a system running at a frequency she was only beginning to tune herself to.

This was not Florence, which had made room for her. This was not Barcelona, which had pulled her into its noise. This was a city that wasn't waiting for her at all, and didn't need anything from her, and would go on running its exquisite machinery whether she learned it or not.

She found, standing there at midnight with an onigiri wrapper in her pocket and eighteen months of floors behind her, that this was almost a relief.

She walked home. The maple was invisible in its slot of sky. She didn't look up.

More of this, she thought, and meant it differently than before.

End of Chapter 1

EASTERN SPARKS (BOOK 2)

Chapter 2: The Weight of Getting It Right

Luca Voss · Tokyo, Japan — Sézanne, Four Seasons Hotel Marunouchi

Luca arrived in Tokyo on a Tuesday in July, carrying one large bag and a notebook he'd been writing in since Paris. The notebook had a wine list from Plénitude folded inside the cover — a habit, not a souvenir. He liked the structure of it. The way information organized into a clear hierarchy. Which bottle, which region, which vintage, which price. Everything exactly where it should be.

The Marunouchi exit from Tokyo Station opened onto a broad, modern concourse — glass and steel, the Imperial Palace gardens somewhere invisible to the left, the Four Seasons visible down the avenue. He'd looked it up. He knew the address. He knew the restaurant was on the 36th floor, that it held two Michelin stars, that the head chef Daniel Calvert had trained in London and Hong Kong before arriving in Tokyo and had built something that wasn't quite French and wasn't quite Japanese and was, by all accounts, exactly itself.

He knew the technical facts. He did not yet know the room.

He checked in to his accommodation — a compact apartment in a serviced building near Hibiya, fifteen minutes' walk from the Four Seasons — and did not sleep. He wasn't tired in the way that needed sleep. He was tight, coiled with the specific tension of someone who has committed to a next-level posting and is now in the building waiting to find out whether next-level means what he thinks it means.

He unpacked. Pressed his uniform. Sat at the small desk with the Tokyo twilight doing something slow and amber outside the window and went through his notebook again.

Florence, Barcelona, Paris, London. The progression made sense on paper. But sense on paper and sense on a floor were different things, and he'd been enough places by now to know that the gap between them was where character happened. Where you found out what you were actually made of.

He wrote one line in the notebook: *Different city. Same question: what does this room need from me?*

Then he closed it and went to bed.

The Sézanne kitchen occupied a space of controlled intensity that Luca recognized and respected immediately. Not chaos managed into order — order maintained against the constant pressure of service. Two different things. London kitchens often ran the first way. Plénitude had run the second. This ran the second, but quieter, the controlled atmosphere turned all the way down until the discipline expressed itself as stillness.

He watched the head chef move from pass to pass on the first morning and understood without being told that this was a room where getting it right was the baseline expectation, not the ceiling. You got it right, and then you got it more precisely right, and then you got it right consistently under conditions that made consistency difficult, and then you were, maybe, beginning.

His floor supervisor was a tall French-Japanese man named Rémy who had been at Sézanne for four years and had the manner of someone who had mastered the patience required to watch new staff make mistakes he'd already catalogued. Not unkind. Just comprehensive. He assigned Luca to the service floor on the third day with one instruction:

"The room is never about you."

Luca didn't nod. He thought about it first, because it deserved to be thought about rather than agreed to reflexively. Then he said: "Understood."

He thought about it for the rest of the day. He'd been told versions of this before — guest-first, invisible service, you're a frame not the painting. He'd understood it technically for years. But something about Rémy's delivery made him feel that he hadn't actually internalized it yet, just intellectualized it, which was a different thing entirely.

The wine pairing was where it happened.

Sézanne's menu paired French technique against Japanese ingredients in ways that looked clean on paper and were deeply intricate in practice. The seventh course, a crab preparation with a dashi beurre blanc, was paired from the list by several routes — sake, white Burgundy, Champagne — and Luca had studied them all. The dashi introduced umami depth that shifted the center of gravity of any wine you put against it. You couldn't just pour a good white Burgundy and call it done. The specific character of the wine determined whether you were enhancing the dish or flattening it.

On his fifth service, he was working a table of four — two Japanese businessmen and their guests, a German couple who were clearly comfortable with European service but tentative about the

Japanese elements. The German man asked, as the seventh course arrived, whether the pairing was the white Burgundy or the sake.

Luca said, without enough thought: "Either works beautifully with this preparation." A hedge. Technically not wrong. Completely useless.

The German man nodded, satisfied. The Japanese host at the table looked at his plate.

It wasn't until later — clearing the next course, watching the German couple use the wrong-for-tonight wine against the dashi in a way that muted the dish — that Luca understood what the answer should have been. Not *either works*. The answer was that the Burgundy that night was a 2019 Meursault from Domaine Roulot with enough minerality to cut through the dashi's weight, while the sake was a junmai daiginjo with a dry finish that extended rather than competed with the umami. They didn't work equally. They worked differently. His job had been to know which one served that specific table's dinner better, and to say so with confidence.

He'd been accurate about the food. He hadn't been accurate about the guest.

After service, he stayed thirty minutes past close, at the counter with the pairing notes for the next three days' menus. Not punishing himself. Accounting. He wanted the gap between his technical knowledge and his floor judgment smaller than it had been tonight. That gap was where good became right. He took notes in his notebook under a single heading: *What the dish is doing vs. what the guest needs to hear*.

Rémy passed the counter at midnight on his way to the back of house, saw the notebook, and said nothing. But he paused for two seconds before continuing, and Luca logged it.

William Daniels was noted in the system as a long-stay guest of the Four Seasons, a regular of the concierge desk, preference for table nine: near the window, facing the room rather than the view. He'd been dining at Sézanne three evenings a week for eleven days before Luca was assigned to his table.

In the VIP notes, in small precise handwriting, was a single annotation: *Prefers recommendations. Does not read the list*.

Luca read it twice. Then he went and spent twenty minutes with the wine list before service, not building a script but building comprehension — what was tonight's kitchen doing, what mood was

it in, what would a person of taste order if they were listening to the menu rather than to their own preferences.

William arrived at 7:15. Tall, silver-haired, a dark wool jacket over a tailored shirt, a watch on his left wrist that was understated and very good. He moved to table nine without being guided, which meant he knew the room. He sat with the ease of someone for whom restaurants were a natural habitat, not a performance space.

Luca presented himself at the table, poured water, opened the sake list.

William looked at it for a moment and then placed it back on the table with a gesture that wasn't dismissive — more like returning something he'd decided not to need.

"What would you drink tonight?" he said. "If it were your dinner."

Luca had read the annotation. He'd half-expected a version of this. What he hadn't expected was how much the question would require of him — not just a recommendation, but an honest answer. *Your dinner*. Not the safest choice, not the premium choice, not the choice most guests in this room would be comfortable with. What would *he* actually order.

He said: "The Juyondai junmai daiginjo. The kitchen tonight is built around restraint — the flavors are clean and precise, nothing competing. The sake matches that quality. It's dry, almost silent, and I think silence is right for what's coming."

A pause. He'd used the word *silence* without meaning to. It just arrived.

William regarded him with those warm brown eyes that, Luca noticed, operated independently of whatever expression was on the rest of his face — they were always doing a separate accounting.

"You're describing the kitchen," William said. "Not the sake."

"Yes," Luca said.

"That's rarer than you'd think."

He ordered the Juyondai. Luca poured it at the right moment in the first course, the small clean twist at the finish, and withdrew without comment.

Over the following two weeks, William Daniels dined at Sézanne seven more times. Luca was assigned to his table on four of those occasions, not by accident — he suspected Rémy had noticed

the quality of the first exchange and wanted to observe whether it had been luck or character.

The conversations developed the way real conversations do: slowly, mostly across the grain of service, in the brief pauses that opened and closed like windows between courses.

William traveled for Brigham Enterprises — something to do with pipe making, briar sourcing, a niche Japanese importer he visited once a year. He mentioned it without ceremony, the way a person mentions the mechanics of a life that has long since been integrated into who they are rather than what they do. What he talked about more — when he talked — was people. Specific people. A warehouse manager in Toronto who had been with the company for twenty-two years and whose judgment William trusted more than any management consultant he'd ever met. A young woman in his accounts department who had flagged a procurement error that would have cost them significantly, and whom he'd given a raise and a new title because the error-catching was a skill and skills should be named and paid for.

Luca listened. He was good at listening. It was one of the floor skills he'd developed earliest and most thoroughly — the capacity to give someone his full attention without the attention being visible. He held it lightly, the way you hold a glass you've just filled, not gripping.

On the fourth occasion, between the third and fourth courses, William said — not in the manner of a revelation but the way you say something you've said before and still believe: "The finest service I've ever received wasn't efficient. It wasn't even technically perfect."

Luca waited.

"A young woman in Paris. The Marais, years ago." William looked at his glass rather than at Luca while he said it, which meant he wasn't performing the memory — he was inside it. "She made me feel that my being there mattered. Not the table, not the bill. Me. The person." He paused. "I don't think she could have articulated exactly what she was doing. I think she just cared. And the caring was visible in everything — the way she described a dish, the way she moved around the room. She made the whole restaurant seem like it was arranged around whoever she was speaking to at that moment. And then she moved to the next table and I imagine she made them feel the same way."

Another pause.

"That's not in any training manual I've read."

"No," Luca said. And then, because it was true and because William deserved a real answer: "But it could be taught. It's an attention skill. You can train someone to see the room the way she saw it."

William looked at him then — properly, with those eyes that accounted for everything.

"You believe that."

"I've watched it be learned," Luca said. "It takes longer than the technical work. But it's not magic."

William sat with that for a moment. Then he returned to his plate with the expression of someone filing an argument for later examination.

Luca withdrew.

Walking back to the pass, he replayed what William had said. A young woman in Paris. Brazilian — he hadn't said that, but something about the phrase *Portuguese-accented* hovered at the edge of the memory, though William hadn't used those words tonight. He'd said it differently, or Luca had assembled it from something. He wasn't sure. He wrote it in his notebook after service, under the heading *W.D. — Marais* — not as a cross-reference, just as detail worth keeping. The kind of detail that usually meant something later.

There was a server on the Sézanne floor named Kepler — mid-twenties, German, technically sharp, the kind of person who'd plateaued at a certain competence and was coasting inside it. He wasn't bad. He was exactly adequate, consistently, and the gap between adequate and right was invisible to him because adequate produced no visible consequences.

Luca noticed him at the wine station on a Friday service — the night's second seating, the room full, Rémy occupied on the far side of the floor. Kepler was decanting a red, the label turned away from the guest, the pour done before the full air exposure the wine needed. Fifteen seconds would have made the difference. He wasn't pouring badly; he was pouring on Kepler's schedule rather than the wine's.

It wasn't a disaster. The guest didn't know. The wine would be fine.

Luca stood at his own station and considered his options in the spare time of a half-second. He could say nothing — not his table, not his problem. He could say something to Rémy later — correct channel, but the moment would be dead by then and nothing would change. He could say something to Kepler now — which would require careful calibration between useful and condescending.

He chose the third option. After the course was cleared, at the wine station, briefly:

"The Chambolle needs two more minutes in the decanter. It's tight tonight."

Kepler looked at him. Then at the decanter. Then: "It poured fine."

"For the next table, try the two minutes." Luca moved away before the conversation became a negotiation.

He didn't know if Kepler did it. He wasn't going to check. He'd said the thing he could say in the time available to say it, which was all he could actually control. The rest was Kepler's.

After service, he wrote in his notebook: *The only floor you can run is yours. You can set an example. You can make one suggestion. You cannot care more about someone's performance than they do.*

He looked at it for a while. It was true. It also felt incomplete — there was something about Kepler's adequacy that bothered him beyond the wine, beyond the one pour. It was the *settling*. The decision — conscious or not — to stop getting better. In a room like this one, in cities like this one, that decision was a kind of waste.

He crossed out the note and wrote: *Adequacy is a choice. So is precision. They look similar from the outside until the moment they don't.*

He folded the notebook shut and walked home along the Imperial Palace moat in the dark.

The moat was still at this hour, a broad black surface with the lights of the city caught in it. He ran it in the mornings; he walked it at night, which was a different relationship with the same water. The morning run was a system: pace, distance, breathing, the body as a machine to be kept tuned. The nighttime walk was something else. He wasn't optimizing. He was just moving, and thinking, and letting the thoughts come and go without organizing them.

He thought about William's Paris server — the one who made each guest feel seen. He tried to put her in his mind and found only a vague outline: someone who cared completely, who made the caring invisible. He'd met a few servers like that in his years on floors. They weren't common. They had something that wasn't exactly taught and wasn't exactly innate — it was cultivated, deliberately, by people who'd decided that the work was worth doing as well as it could be done.

He thought about what he'd said to William: *It could be taught.*

He believed that. He just didn't know yet how you'd build the teaching.

He walked the moat's length and turned back and the city was enormous around him, entirely indifferent, running its machinery at a frequency he was still learning to hear. The loneliness of it was a clean, specific thing — not unhappiness, just the sharpness of being very good at your work in a city that demanded you be better than very good, and not yet having anyone to compare notes with.

In his bag, the notebook. In the notebook, the wine lists, the pairing observations, the VIP annotations, the one line about Kepler, the one line about William's Paris server, and, filed under a date two weeks earlier, a passing note from a colleague: *Table nine VIP — Voss table. Some European woman around the same age — same Four Seasons concierge book. Maybe one of yours.*

He hadn't thought about it when he'd written it down. He filed information. That was how he worked.

The moat water held its reflections perfectly. He watched them until a bicycle passed and the ripples dismantled the image into light.

He walked home.

On his last Thursday service of the Tokyo posting — a month from now he'd transfer to Bangkok, the contract already confirmed at Nusara — William appeared at table nine and, for the first time, brought a guest: a quiet Japanese man in his sixties who turned out to be the briar importer, the whole reason for the Tokyo visits. They spoke little across the meal. The companionship between them was old and comfortable — two men who had reached the part of a business relationship where they didn't need to fill the space.

Luca served them with total attention and minimal intrusion. The Juyondai again, without being asked. He poured it at the right moment, withdrew without comment.

At the end of the evening, at the coat check, William paused.

"Bangkok next?" he said. He'd heard, apparently, from the concierge or from the hotel staff. Four Seasons people knew each other.

"In four weeks," Luca said.

"Good city for what you do," William said. And then — putting his coat on, not making it a moment: "The people there will teach you things a kitchen can't."

He left.

Luca stood at the coat check for two seconds after he'd gone. He filed the comment: *The people*. Not the technique. Not the system.

He'd been saying it in different words for two weeks. William was consistent. Luca was beginning to understand this wasn't coincidence. The man had a thesis he was living, not performing.

He went back to the floor to finish close.

End of Chapter 2